

Beyond the Numbers

A Deep Dive into American Airlines Loyalty Program



Project Overview

COMPANY

**American
Airlines**

PROGRAM

AAdvantage

FOCUS

Generation Z

IN PARTNERSHIP WITH

American Airlines Marketing Team

OUR GOAL

A student-led analysis built to understand why Gen Z is not engaging with AAdvantage, and what the American Airlines Marketing Team can do to change that.

627,000+ Reddit posts analyzed

4 years of data

3 competing airlines

What we found surprised us
and it should change how AA thinks about Gen Z.



The Loyalty Gap

30%

of all air travelers will be
Gen Z by 2030

Gen Z loyalty enrollment today

65% vs **89%**

Gen Z enrolled

Boomers enrolled

OUR RESEARCH QUESTION

Why isn't Gen Z joining
AAdvantage — and what
should AA do about it?

What we found:

AA doesn't have a product problem. It has a perception problem.



What We Know About Gen Z Travelers

1

Gen Z Language & Identity

How they communicate

Gen Z slang is not noise. It is a systematic linguistic system used to signal identity and evaluate brands. Misreading it means misreading the consumer.

Huda, "Language Change in the Communication of Generation Z" (2024)

Sadigzade, "It's Giving Linguistic Innovation" (2026)

2

The Authenticity Gap

What drives trust or kills it

Gen Z can tell when a brand is performing. Forced or "cringe" messaging does not just fail; it actively pushes them away.

SKIM Group, "The Authenticity Gap" (2025)

44%

prioritize brand
authenticity above all

32%

abandon brands with
"cringe" voice

3

Reddit as Signal

Why this data source

Anonymity and long-form posts make Reddit uniquely suited for NLP. Candid feedback surfaces here that other platforms suppress.

IJCSMC, "Sentiment Analysis of Reddit Comments" (2022)

Omira, "Dynamics of Reddit Comment Popularity," Stanford (2024)

Forbes, "Turning Reddit Reviews into a Marketing Gold Mine" (2026)





Building the Model:

A Tool AA Can Run on Their Own Data

WHAT IS THIS DATA?

SYNTHETIC TRAINING DATASET

129,880 Airline Passenger Records

This is a **synthetic, structured dataset** - purpose-built to mirror real airline satisfaction surveys. It is the foundation on which our machine learning models were trained, validated, and tested.

WHY SYNTHETIC?

Real airline proprietary data is confidential. Synthetic data lets us **build and validate models now** - so AA can plug in their own passenger data and get immediate, actionable predictions.

DATASET VARIABLES

14 service ratings · Flight distance · Delay minutes Travel class · Travel type · Age / Generation **Target: Loyalty Program Enrollment (Y/N)**

WHY IT MATTERS

ML Model 1 — XGBoost Classifier

Predicts **which passengers are likely to enroll** in AAdvantage — and which aren't. Accuracy: 96.4%

ML Model 2 — SHAP Feature Importance

Ranks **which service attributes drive** enrollment decisions — giving AA a ranked action list

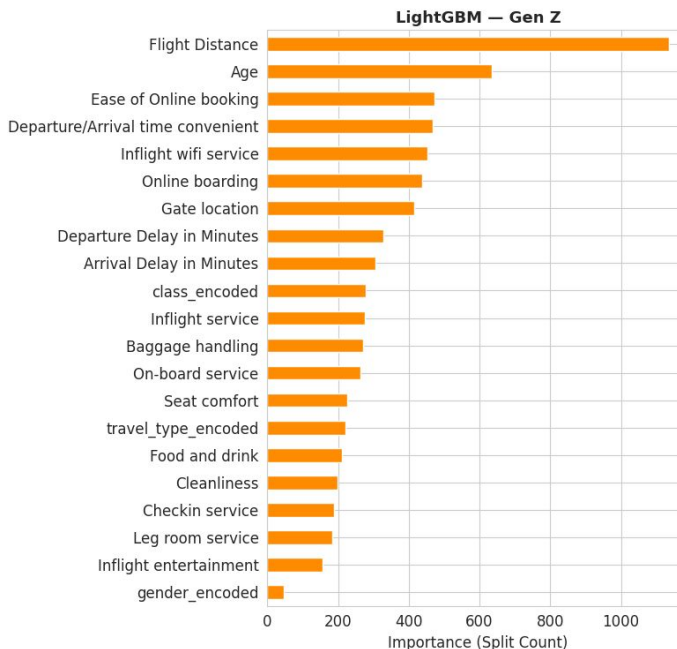
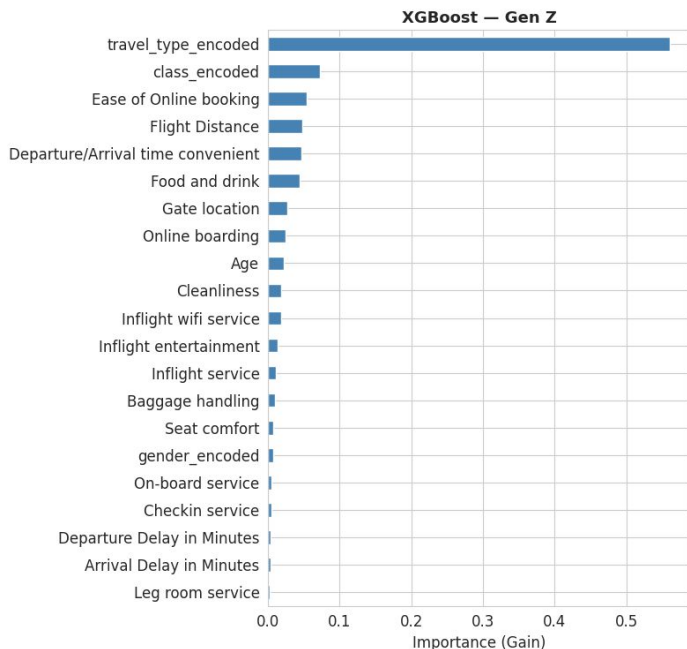
TIED TO THE HOOK

These models *quantify and explain* the gap, giving AA a data-driven roadmap.



Kaggle Data and Findings

Feature Importance Comparison — Gen Z Loyalty Drivers

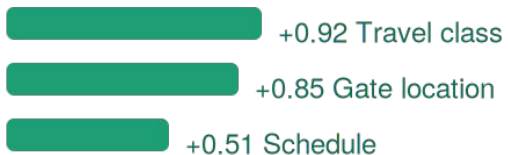


Kaggle Data and Findings

Same generation. Completely different drivers.

Traveler A: enrolled (91.5%)

What pushed them toward loyalty:



What pulled them away:



Business traveler, values convenience

Traveler B: not enrolled (0%)

What pushed them toward loyalty:



What pulled them away:



Personal traveler, poor digital experience

One campaign can't reach both. AA needs different messages for different Gen Z segments.



Three Datasets

627,000+ posts · 4 years · 3 airlines · Zero surveys.

DATASET 1

Loyalty Program Sentiment

245,345

posts and comments

How AAdvantage is perceived among loyalty program users — no surveys, no brand filters.

10 subreddits · Jan 2022 to Mar 2026

DATASET 2

Gen Z Travel Experience

289,500

posts and comments

What Gen Z actually cares about when flying, before loyalty even enters the conversation.

3 subreddits · Jan 2022 to Mar 2026

DATASET 3

Competitive Comparison

316,000+

posts and comments

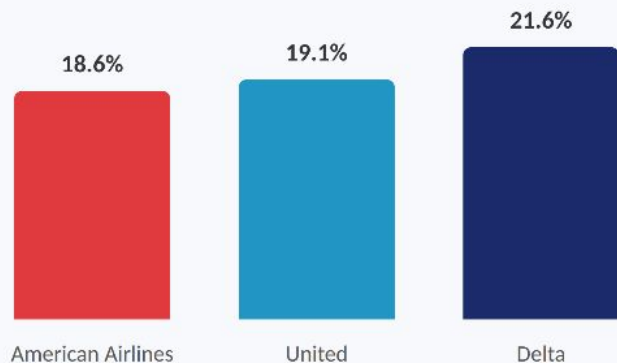
AA vs Delta vs United, side by side, same model and same methodology — any difference is the airlines.

3 subreddits · Jan 2022 to Apr 2026

Together: why isn't Gen Z joining AAdvantage, and what would change that?

The Mindshare Gap

Negative Rate by Airline



The Problem: **Invisibility** in Loyalty Program Conversation

- AA's challenge is a lack of relevance
- AA has the lowest Negative sentiment rate
- AA Generates significantly less conversation than competitors

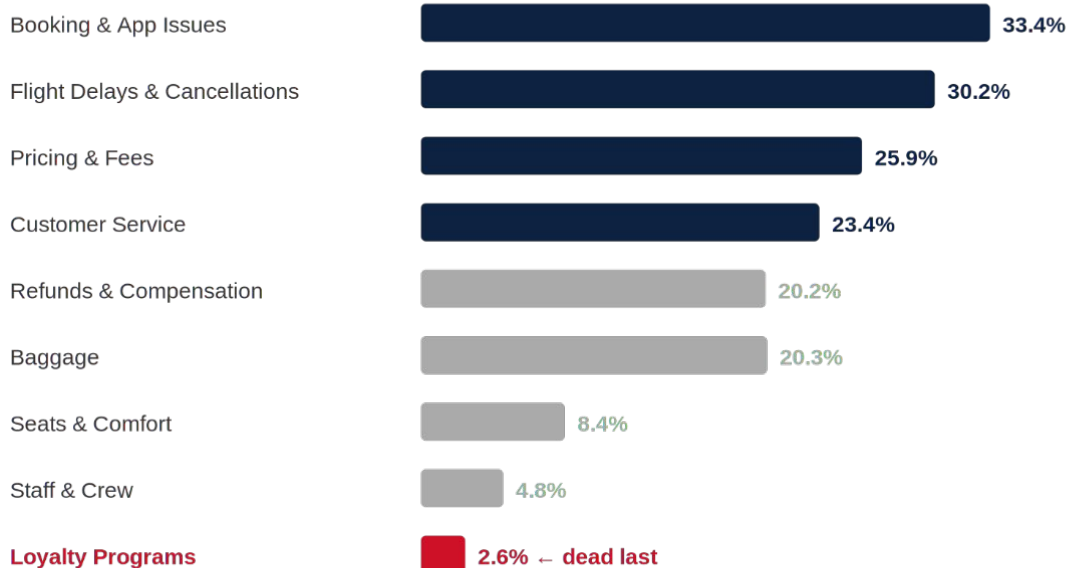
Raw Volume by Airline



Loyalty Isn't Even in the Conversation

WHAT GEN Z COMPLAINS ABOUT WHEN FLYING

% of negative posts · avg across r/Flights, r/solotravel, r/TravelHacks



KEY FINDINGS

Industry-wide problems, not AA-specific

Delays, booking friction, and refund difficulty are Gen Z's top frustrations across every airline. AA is not singled out.

Pricing is a defining Gen Z concern

Pricing and fees rank in the top 3 in r/TravelHacks, the most Gen Z-aligned subreddit. Value transparency matters.

Loyalty is completely off Gen Z's radar

Even when actively discussing travel, Gen Z almost never mentions loyalty programs. It is not part of how they think about flying.

CORE INSIGHT

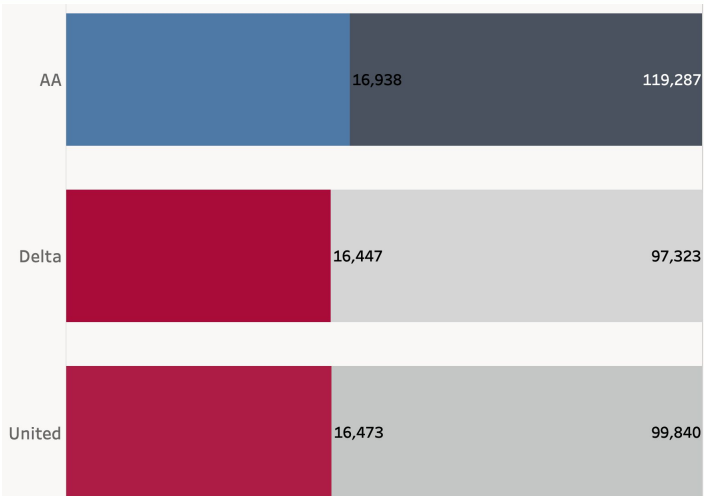
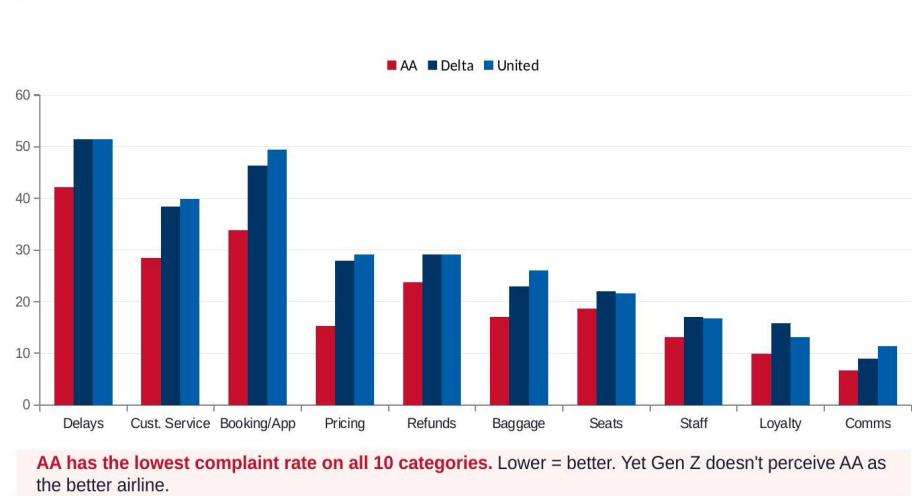
Loyalty is not part of how Gen Z thinks about flying. Yet.

That is the opportunity.

AA Has a Better Product, Gen Z Doesn't Know It

Same keywords. Same model. Same date range. Any difference = the airlines themselves.

American Airlines r/americanairlines ~119K Gen Z records Negative Rate45.81%	Delta r/delta 97,323 Gen Z records Negative Rate45.95%	United r/unitedairlines 99,840 Gen Z records Negative Rate41.71%
---	---	---



The Loyalty Visibility Gap

The Paradox: Best Performance, Worst Perception

Product Reality

AA leads on all 10 complaint categories

Delays: 42% vs Delta 52%, United 51%

Customer Service: 29% vs Delta 38%, United 40%

Booking & App: 34% vs Delta 46%, United 49%

Gen Z talks about all 3 airlines at equal volume

→ Brand awareness is not the problem

⚠ AAdvantage Loyalty Program Visibility

Loyalty Program Mentions in Negative Posts

15.8%

Delta SkyMiles

13.1%

United MileagePlus

-37% gap

9.9%

AA AAdvantage

What This Means

Higher complaints = Higher engagement

Gen Z isn't using AAdvantage enough to complain

AA doesn't have a product problem. AA has a perception problem and a loyalty visibility problem.



Recommendations for American Airlines

WHAT THE DATA SHOWS

AA outperforms Delta and United on every single complaint category.

Delays, customer service, booking, pricing, refunds, baggage, staff. AA wins on all of them. Gen Z just doesn't know it.

AA lowest complaint rate in

9 of 9

complaint categories vs Delta and United

WHAT AA SHOULD DO

Show up where Gen Z researches travel

Reddit, TikTok, YouTube. Real traveler comparisons, "what I expected vs what happened" content.

Lead with proof, not messaging

Gen Z doesn't trust ads. They trust other users. AA's story needs to be told by travelers, not by AA.

Convert data into content

AA has the numbers. Fewer delays, better service, lower complaint rates. Make that story visible.

Tied to finding:

AA doesn't have a product problem. It has a perception problem.



Recommendations for American Airlines

WHAT THE DATA SHOWS

Earning miles is the #1 complaint in AA's loyalty conversation.

48.9% of AA's negative loyalty posts mention earning structure. This is a program design problem, not a service problem.

of negative loyalty posts mention earning miles

48.9%

the single largest complaint theme · Dataset 1

WHAT AA SHOULD DO

Lower the barrier to earning

Trip-completion bonuses, non-flight earning, partner dining and transit rewards.

Make progress visible in the app

Progress bars, milestone unlocks, trip streaks. Gamification converts occasional flyers into loyal ones.

Position AAdvantage as easy to start now

Not a program you grow into over years. A smart, low-risk program worth starting today.

Tied to finding:

The #1 complaint is the earn structure. Fix that, and you fix the reason people disengage.



Recommendations for American Airlines

WHAT THE DATA SHOWS

AAdvantage generates 3.5x less loyalty conversation than competitors.

Delta and United's loyalty communities are active, vocal, and self-sustaining. AA's isn't.

Higher complaint rates signal engagement, not failure.

fewer AAdvantage discussions vs competitors

3.5x

on Reddit · Dataset 1

WHAT AA SHOULD DO

Create moments worth posting about

Limited-time perks, surprise upgrades, milestone rewards. Give Gen Z something shareable.

Partner with loyalty and travel influencers

Gen Z trusts peer content over brand messaging. AA needs organic credibility, not paid visibility.

Build community, not just customers

Delta and United win because people talk about their programs. Give Gen Z a reason to talk about AA.

Tied to finding:

You can't buy Gen Z trust. AAdvantage needs to earn its way into the conversation.

American Airlines
You are why we fly™

